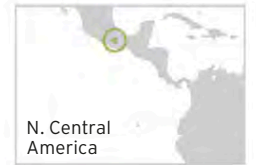




The **figurative designs** generally consist of a **single continuous line** that does not cross itself

Monte Albán

The capital of the Zapotec civilization, carved out of a mountain overlooking the Valley of Oaxaca



One of the first cities to be established in Mesoamerica, Monte Albán was continually inhabited over a period of about 1,400 years from about 500 BCE. Occupying a commanding position on a mountain ridge in southern Mexico, the city became the center of a state covering a large part of the Oaxaca valley.

City on a mountain

Most strikingly, the site comprises a number of levels and terraces cut into the top and flanks of the mountain, forming the bases for the various zones of the city. At the top is the civic center, consisting of a Main Plaza with various ceremonial structures; to the east and west of this are temples and palaces set on platforms; and at the north and south ends of the plaza are larger platforms accessed by magnificent stairways. As the city grew in importance and expanded, terraces were built on the hillsides around it and fortifications were added. The city was gradually abandoned from about the 9th century CE and only extensively excavated and restored in the 20th century.



△ ZAPOTEC RELIEF

A carved relief representation of the bird god Pico Ancho, this figure shows the stylized designs and patterns characteristic of Zapotec art.

The complex includes a **custom-built court** for the **ritual ball game**

▽ PLATFORMS AND STAIRWAYS

Grand staircases are a feature of the city center, linking the different levels at either end of the main esplanade and leading to the platforms of the monuments and ceremonial buildings.

